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GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

NITHYA RAMAN meets with supporters at the Original Farmers Market after Karen Bass conceded defeat.

Raman defeats Bass to become the next mayor of Los Angeles

Blue wave and young voters help secure the win for progressive City Council member.

BY NOAH GOLDBERG

Nithya Raman will be the next mayor of Los Angeles, making her the first challenger to defeat an incumbent L.A. mayor in more than two decades.

Mayor Karen Bass called Raman on Thursday to concede the race after the latest tally from Tuesday's election showed Raman with 52% of the vote compared with 48% for Bass, with 76% of the expected votes counted.

"Los Angeles, I'm deeply honored to be your next mayor," Raman, 45, said in a video statement. "I also wanted to pay tribute to Mayor Karen Bass, someone who has given decades of her life to making this city what it is today."

Bass, 73, thanked her supporters and said she accepted the decision of the voters.

"While this is not the outcome we hoped for, the people of Los Angeles have spoken," Bass said in a statement. "I have called Councilmember Nithya Raman to congratulate her on her victory, and I have committed to ensuring a smooth and seamless transition. Moving this city forward is what Los Angeles needs from all of us.

"Four years ago, you elected me as the first Black woman mayor in the history of Los Angeles," Bass said. "You gave me the honor of serving the city that raised me, and every single day since, I have carried that responsibility with me."

Raman's win capped off a historic sprint of a campaign. The City Council member entered the mayoral race in the final hours before the filing deadline after deciding to run the night before, going up against a onetime ally in a move that infuriated elected Democrats in L.A. who nearly unanimously supported Bass in her reelection bid.

The initial vote count after polls closed Tuesday night had Raman slightly behind Bass, but analysts saw it as a sign that Raman would win. Polls have consistently shown Raman to be heavily favored by younger, more progressive voters, who tend to turn in their ballots later than older voters.

Late-arriving mail-in ballots pushed Raman ahead, and by Thursday morning she was leading Bass by nearly 35,000 votes.

Raman and Bass were locked in a tight and contentious race up until election day, with final polling in the race showing the second-term council member

[See **Mayor,** A8]

What's ahead for L.A. under a new leader

By David Zahniser, Colleen Shalby and Itzel Luna

Bike lanes. Housing vouchers. A new police chief and many more new apartments, even in single-family neighborhoods.

And above all, data to find out if City Hall programs are working.

Mayor-elect Nithya Raman won't represent a radical ideological break from her opponent, one-term incumbent Mayor Karen Bass. Like Bass, she's a Democrat who believes in ending homelessness, keeping the city safe and delivering basic services.

But Raman is expected to push the city to the left on public safety, while also advancing urbanist policies that favor public transit, greater housing production and the redesign of city streets to improve safety and support alternatives to driving.

Rick Cole, a former deputy Los Angeles mayor who advised Raman throughout the campaign, said she's dead serious about her campaign slogan "a city that works" — taking steps to ensure that streets, sidewalks and other parts of the city infrastructure are repaired, while also providing prompt responses to 911 calls.

Raman intends to be a hands-on manager, he said, improving coordination between city departments and analyzing ways to make them more effective.

"L.A. has been flying blind when it comes to measuring the impacts of the dollars spent," said Cole, a Pasadena City Council member. "That is going to change."

As mayor, Raman will have the power to hire and fire the managers of dozens of city agencies and appoint or remove hundreds of citizen commissioners — most of them volunteers — who will serve as an extension of her

[See **Agenda,** A8]

Now the hard part: Governing

Raman will face chronic problems in the city and in city government, Steve Lopez writes. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

NEWSOM COMMUTES ALL STATE DEATH SENTENCES

Costs and inequity are reasons to give 548 prisoners life without parole, governor says.

BY TARYN LUNA AND SONJA SHARP

Gov. Gavin Newsom told the California Supreme Court on Thursday that he will commute the death sentences of all 548 state prisoners awaiting execution, reducing their punishments to life in prison without parole.

Newsom can commute about 40% of the death sentences with the stroke of a pen, but the rest will require the high court's approval in order to be finalized.

The mass commutation would apply to men and women convicted of some of the most heinous acts in the state's history. Newsom and other opponents of capital punishment have long argued that the process is costly, cruel and discriminatory, with death sentences disproportionately handed down to defendants of color.

"I take this action because I firmly believe that state-sanctioned killing is incompatible with California's values, undermines the foundation of our legal system, and diminishes each of us," Newsom wrote in a letter to Californians explaining his decision. "I know we cannot execute people in our imperfect legal system and remain true to our core values, first among them justice and human decency."

The move comes in Newsom's final months as governor and as he considers a run for president. Reducing the death sentences could help him in a primary with a Democratic base of like-minded liberal voters, but potentially hurt him in a general election with a national electorate that supports capital punishment.

The decision to officially spare the condemned inmates is largely symbolic in a state that has not executed a prisoner since 2006, though experts say it could save millions of dollars in court costs every year. Thirteen inmates have been killed since voters reinstated the death penalty in 1978. The state's electorate reaffirmed its support for the death penalty a decade ago, voting down a ballot initiative that would have abolished capital punishment. Polls show its popularity has waned in the years since.

Despite his outspoken opposition to state-sanctioned executions, the governor has declined to use his political influence with voters to pursue a ballot mea-

[See **Newsom,** A14]

Midterm results offer reset for 2028

For both parties, a shifting map requires changing strategies in race for White House.

BY JUSTINE MCDANIEL, ANA CEBALLOS AND KEVIN RECTOR

WASHINGTON — Democratic upsets in this year's midterms, which stretched from the suburbs of Atlanta to rural Kansas, could reshape the electoral map that governs presidential politics — and, with it, the calculus for each party in the fight for the nation's top office in 2028.

Democrats were already cautioning against overconfidence, discussing how to translate their midterm success into more lasting power and to draw back Tuesday's voters in 2028.



TOM BRENNER Pool Photo

VICE PRESIDENT JD Vance appeared to be signaling a 2028 run by pinning blame on the Iran war.

For Republicans, the defeat set off something close to an existential crisis, with would-be contenders for the party's presidential nomination openly debating what had gone wrong and how the party should regroup after voters rebuked President Trump's agenda.

And members of both parties were taking stock of the deep reach Democrats demonstrated Tuesday, with Senate, House and state legislative seats flipped in red strongholds that have not been up for grabs in a presidential race

[See **Results,** A6]

Trump Justice official resigns

Assistant Atty. Gen. Dhillon has foisted president's agenda on civil rights office.

BY KEVIN RECTOR

Assistant Atty. Gen. Harmeet Dhillon, a California attorney who radically reshaped the Justice Department's Civil Rights Division to focus on political issues important to President Trump — including by targeting transgender rights and launching a nationwide hunt for alleged voter fraud by noncitizens — resigned her post Thursday.

In a resignation letter and in a post to X — where she routinely lambasted liberal policy and touted her office's legal work to dismantle it — Dhillon said serving as the division's chief was an honor.

"We ushered in the downfall of illegal DEI, we fought to protect women and girls' sports, and so much more," she wrote on X. "I want to thank President Trump for giving me this opportunity. I look forward to what's next!"

Critics of Dhillon — including prominent civil rights leaders who had opposed her confirmation to the post — cheered her departure, saying she had flipped the storied Civil Rights Division on its head by attacking pillars of its past work, such as affirmative action policies, diversity, equity and inclusion initiatives, LGBTQ+ rights and voting rights.

"Is Harmeet running from a sinking ship? Trying

[See **Dhillon,** A6]

Reservoir project clears opposition

Sacramento-area plan needed, Newsom says. Critics see potential environmental harms.

BY IAN JAMES

California water regulators have approved a permit for Sites Reservoir, clearing the way for construction of the state's first new major reservoir in decades.

Plans call for two large dams about 300 feet high, as well as nine smaller ones, holding water pumped from the Sacramento River and inundating about 15,000 acres in a valley northwest of Sacramento.

After a heated debate, the State Water Resources Control Board voted unanimously late Wednesday to approve the water right permit for the reservoir near the community of Maxwell.

"We're living with more extreme droughts and floods, and a growing need to store water during wet periods. Sites is built for exactly that," Board Chair E. Joaquin Esquivel said.

State officials and managers of water agencies said the $7-billion reservoir will be a critical part of California's efforts to adapt to climate change.

Gov. Gavin Newsom celebrated the decision, saying it shows "California can get big infrastructure projects moving again." He called it a smart investment, saying: "Now it's time to get shovels in the ground."

Construction is scheduled to begin next year and conclude in 2034.

Opponents, including environmental activists and fishing advocates, urged the board to reject the permit, saying the reservoir would siphon too much water out of the Sacramento River and harm salmon and other na-

[See **Reservoir,** A14]



ALISHIA ABODUNDE Getty Images

ACTOR CONVICTED

London judge says Russell Brand faces "significant" prison term after a jury Thursday found him guilty of rape and sexual assault. **WORLD, A3**

Gang mediator arrested in plot

Nonprofit figure Skipp Townsend and four others are held in conspiracy to commit murder. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

CalRecycle sets low bar for waste

The benchmark for reducing single-use packaging is a third of '24 figure. **CLIMATE, A9**

Weather
Lots of sun.
L.A. Basin: 84/57. **B6**

Markets **A12**
Opinion Voices **A13**

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